

A durable tribute to self-love

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Suresh Menon

In 1984, written a few decades before that year, George Orwell showed how the state's real genius lay in taking private joy and turning it into propaganda.

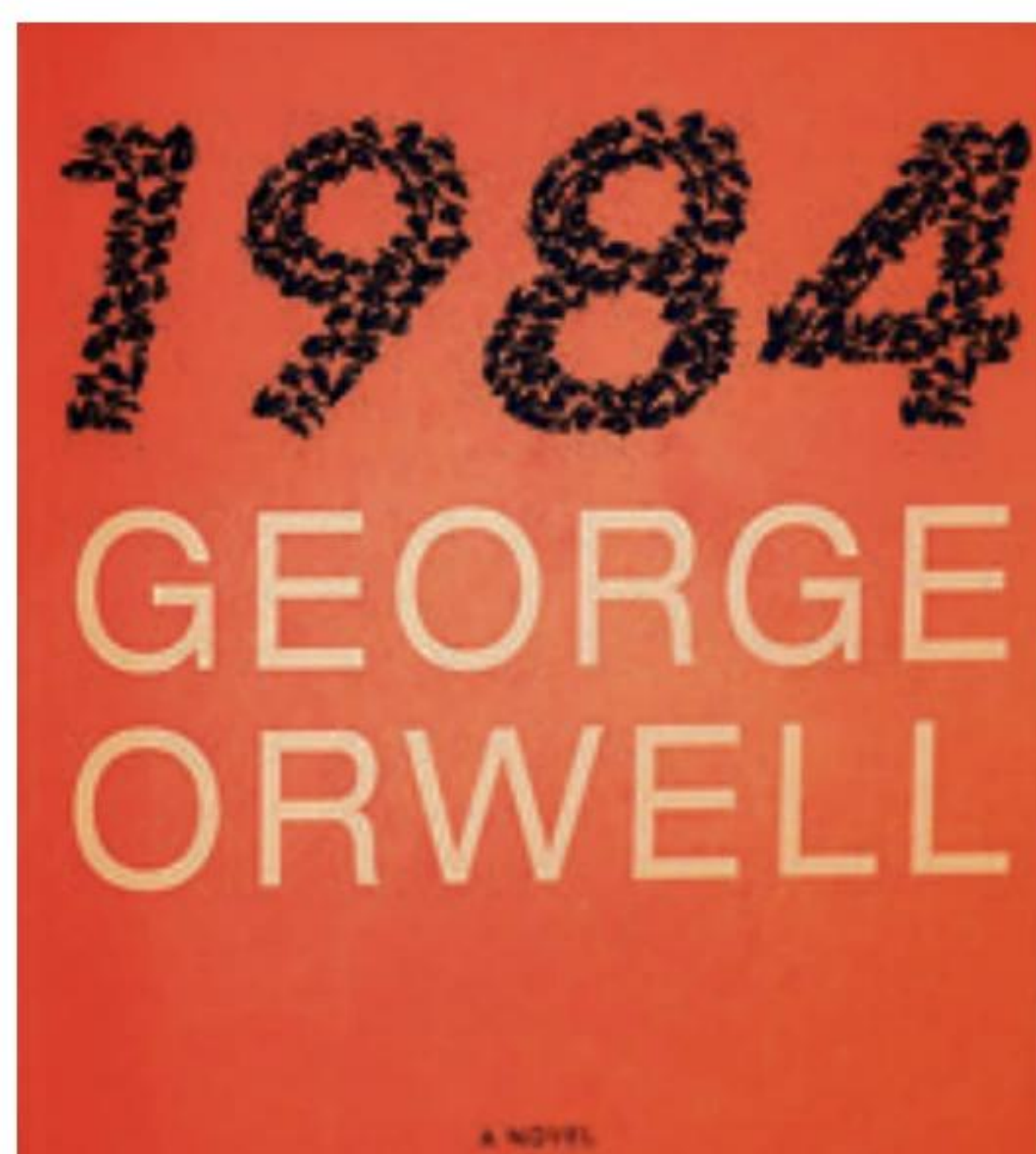
The politician who names a stadium after himself is engaged in a similar act: the conversion of collective celebration into personal myth. Politicians hunger for 'legacy'. Where artists leave behind paintings and athletes records, they prefer concrete.

A century from now, fans might struggle to remember the names of players who made history within the walls of a stadium, but the name of the politician after whom it is named will remain. It's a durable tribute to self-love. **Even Ozymandias (or**

Rameses II if you prefer), that ancient champion of vanity, had to rely on a poet to immortalise his ruins. Today's Ozymandias doesn't need a Shelley, he has the local public works department.

It began with the ancient Roman emperors who loved putting their monograms on temples. Chances are that more sports stadiums around the world are named after politicians than athletes. In India we have stadiums named after Nehru, his daughter Indira, and her sons Rajiv and Sanjay. More recently the Narendra Modi Stadium was inaugurated by Narendra Modi himself.

So it should come as no surprise when we hear that Donald Trump is requesting that the Commanders NFL Stadium to be built in Washington (cost: 3.7 billion dollars) be named after him. As with all his requests, there is an "...or else" at the end of it. "It's what the



Words of wisdom: In his novel 1984, George Orwell showed how the state's real genius lay in taking private joy and turning it into propaganda. AFP

President wants, and it will probably happen," a White House official was quoted as saying.

By the time the stadium opens in 2030, Trump will be out of office, so it will be interesting to see what happens.

You can't help but admire the audacity. Athletes have to perform, the politician buys immortality with a threat. The line between narcissism and branding disappears. *Look on my Works, ye Mighty, and despair!* Ozymandias could have picked up a pointer or two.

Indian politicians have a cover story: naming the stadium after myself was the public's wish. Or, I couldn't say 'no' to my partymen; that might be insulting them. The U.S. President can't be bothered with

such niceties. I want, I get, and the rest of you can suck it up.

In 2011, India won the cricket World Cup at a stadium named after a Mumbai politician. Many fans who cheered for M. S. Dhoni's team then will have to look up the scorecards for details now. **The image of Dhoni striking the winning six will remain for longer than the statistics of his score. But even that will fade with time and new generations. But the name of the venue, Wankhede Stadium, will be refreshed every time a match is played there.**

In 1934, the governor of Bombay (as it was known then) laid the foundation stone for a stadium named after him. His name was Michael Knatchbull. Doesn't ring a bell? He was the fifth Baron Brabourne. Immortality!